

FREELANCEOS - 2026 EDITION

# The Freelance Pricing Playbook

**Stop underselling yourself in 7 days.**

A practical system for freelancers stuck at \$40/hr who should be charging \$150. 8 chapters. 3 worksheets. No fluff.

**By FreelanceOS**

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# Read This First

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This is not a book about confidence. It is not a book about mindset. It is a book about the seven things you can change this week to charge two to four times what you charge now without scaring off the people who already pay you.

It works for designers, developers, writers, marketers, consultants, video editors, and anyone else who sells brain time. It does not work if you sell physical products or if your business is built on volume. The whole premise here is that you can charge more for the same hour because the hour is worth more to a different kind of buyer.

I wrote this because I spent four years charging \$45/hr and another two years climbing painfully to \$90, and I now charge between \$175 and \$250 depending on the project. The jump from \$45 to \$175 took eighteen months. It should have taken three. Most of what slowed me down was not skill. It was the absence of a clear playbook for how rates actually move.

How to use this book:

Read chapters 1 through 3 first. They reset how you think about your number. Do the rate calculator in chapter 3 before you do anything else. Then jump to whichever chapter matches what you are stuck on right now. Chapter 4 if you have current clients to migrate. Chapter 5 if you keep losing money on calls. Chapter 6 if clients keep stalling on payment. Chapter 7 if you keep getting compared to cheaper competitors. Chapter 8 if you want a 90-day plan.

Three worksheets at the back. Use them. They are the difference between reading this and changing your business.

You should be done in two evenings. After that it is execution.

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# Chapter 1: Why You're Underpriced

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There are five reasons freelancers stay underpriced. Most of you have at least three of them. Almost none of you have all five fixed.

## Reason 1: You priced yourself off your last salary

When you went freelance, you took your old salary, divided by 2,000 hours, and called that your hourly rate. Maybe you added 20% because someone told you to. So if you used to make \$80,000 a year as a developer, you set your rate at \$48/hr.

That number is wrong by about half. A salaried developer at \$80K costs the company roughly \$110K to \$130K once you add benefits, payroll tax, equipment, software, office, sick days, and the 20% of their time spent in meetings that produce nothing. Your equivalent freelance rate to match that lifestyle is \$75 to \$95/hr, and that is before you account for the fact that you bill maybe 60% of the hours you work because the rest is admin, sales, and unpaid revisions.

Real number: if you want to clear \$80K take-home as a US freelancer, you need to bill around \$120/hr at 25 billable hours per week. Not \$48.

## Reason 2: You compete on the freelance marketplace floor

If you are on Upwork, Fiverr, or Contra browsing the public job feed, you are pricing against someone in a country with a \$400/month rent. You will lose that race. The freelancers charging \$200/hr are not on those feeds. They are getting referrals, inbound from a portfolio site, or repeat work from the three clients they signed two years ago.

The fastest single thing you can do to raise your rate is leave the public job feed. You do not need to leave the platform. You just need to stop bidding against 47 other people for a \$300 logo.

## Reason 3: You quote based on time, not outcome

A client does not care that the landing page took you 11 hours. They care that the landing page is going to convert at 4% instead of 1.8% and that the difference is worth \$40,000 a year to them. When you quote \$90/hr times 11 hours = \$990, you have anchored them on your time. When you quote \$4,500 to ship a landing page that lifts conversion, you have anchored them on the outcome. Same work. Different number. Different conversation.

## Reason 4: You are afraid of the silence after the number

This is the real one. You say "\$2,000" and the client pauses, and the pause feels like four years long, and you panic and say "but I can do \$1,500 if budget is tight." You just lost \$500 by talking. Stop talking after you say the number. The pause is the client doing math, not rejecting you.

I lost roughly \$18,000 over two years to this single habit before I noticed it. Count the seconds in your head if you have to. They will speak first.

## Reason 5: Your portfolio is selling the wrong thing

Most freelancer portfolios show what they made. Premium freelancer portfolios show what their work did. "Designed a website for X" is a \$60/hr portfolio. "Redesigned X's checkout, lifted completion rate 22%, recovered \$180K/year in abandoned revenue" is a \$200/hr portfolio. The work might be identical. The framing is not.

## Diagnostic: Which of these is killing your rate?

Score yourself 1 to 5 on each (1 = not me, 5 = exactly me):

- \* I set my rate by dividing an old salary by 2,000.
- \* I am still bidding on public marketplace jobs.
- \* I quote in hours or days, not project totals.
- \* I have softened my price after a client paused.
- \* My portfolio describes what I built, not what it produced.

Anything 4 or 5 is a leak. Add up the numbers. If you scored over 15, you are leaving 50%+ on the table. The rest of this book fixes each one in order.

### DO THIS TODAY

- \* Write down your current effective hourly rate (last 90 days revenue divided by hours worked, including unpaid).
- \* Score yourself on the five-question diagnostic.
- \* Pick the highest-scoring leak as the chapter you read next.
- \* Cancel any active marketplace bids you are competing on price for.
- \* Open a doc called "Rate Migration" and write the date at the top. You'll use it through the rest of the book.

# Chapter 2: The Three Pricing Models

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There are only three real ways to price freelance work. Hourly, project, and value. Most of you are using one when you should be using another.

## Hourly

Hourly is selling your time as inventory. Client pays for hours, you log hours, invoice goes out monthly.

When to use it:

- \* Open-ended retainers with no defined scope.
- \* Ongoing maintenance, support, or consulting where the work shifts week to week.
- \* Clients who explicitly want to control budget by capping hours.

When not to use it:

- \* Defined deliverables with a clear start and end.
- \* Anything where you are faster than average. Hourly punishes speed.
- \* New clients who do not yet trust you. They will scrutinize every hour.

Formula: target take-home + business costs + tax + buffer, divided by realistic billable hours.

Example: You want \$100K take-home. Add \$15K business costs (software, accountant, equipment). Add 25% tax = \$28,750. Total target: \$143,750. Realistic billable hours at 25/week for 48 weeks = 1,200 hours. Rate = \$120/hr.

If you are charging less than that and your goal is \$100K, you are not going to hit your goal. The math is the math.

## Project (fixed fee)

Project pricing is selling a defined deliverable for a fixed price. Client pays for the outcome, not the time. You eat the risk if it takes longer; you keep the upside if it goes faster.

When to use it:

- \* Defined scope with a clear deliverable (a website, a logo, a 12-page PDF, a CRM migration).
- \* Repeat work you have done five or more times and can estimate accurately.
- \* New clients who need price certainty before committing.

When not to use it:

- \* Vague scope. If you cannot list what is included in three bullets, do not fixed-bid it.
- \* Work that depends heavily on client input timing. They will block you and you will eat the cost.

Formula: estimated hours x your hourly target rate x 1.4 risk multiplier.

Example: You can build a Webflow marketing site in 40 hours. Your hourly target is \$120. Project price =  $40 \times 120 \times 1.4 = \$6,720$ . Round up to \$6,950 or down to \$6,500 depending on which side of psychology you want to land on. Quote it as \$6,500 with two rounds of revision and a 50% deposit.

The 1.4 multiplier is not greed. It is the buffer for revisions, scope drift, the day your kid gets sick, and the inevitable client request that arrives at 9 PM Friday.

## Value

Value pricing is selling a percentage of the outcome you create. The client pays based on what your work is worth to them, not what it costs you to make.

When to use it:

- \* High-leverage work tied to revenue (sales pages, ad campaigns, conversion optimization, product launches, fundraising decks).
- \* Established clients who trust your judgment.
- \* Projects where you can credibly estimate the financial outcome.

When not to use it:

- \* New relationships. They will not pay value rates to a stranger.
- \* Work that is hard to attribute (brand identity, internal tools, support).
- \* Work where you cannot ask basic financial questions without scaring the client.

Formula: estimated value created x 8% to 15% capture rate.

Example: Client runs a Shopify store doing \$2M/year. You estimate a redesign + checkout optimization will lift revenue by 12%, which is \$240K/year. Capture 10% = \$24K. That is your project price. The client is happy because the redesign pays for itself in five weeks. You are happy because the same job at hourly would have been \$9,000.

To do value pricing without sounding ridiculous, you need to ask three questions on the discovery call:

- \* What is this worth to you if it works?
- \* What does it cost you to not have this fixed?
- \* What is the next thing you would do with the money this generates?

If they cannot answer those questions, they are not a value-pricing client. Quote project.

## Which one for you, right now

If you are under \$80/hr: use project pricing on every new engagement. Stop quoting hourly to anyone you have known less than 90 days.

If you are \$80 to \$150/hr: use project pricing on most jobs, hourly only for retainers, and start running value-pricing experiments on revenue-tied work.

If you are over \$150/hr: value pricing on outcome work, project on defined deliverables, hourly only for trusted long-term clients.

**DO THIS TODAY**

- \* Audit your current clients. Note which model each one is on.
- \* Identify one client who should be on project pricing but is on hourly. Plan the migration (chapter 4).
- \* Calculate your target hourly rate using the formula above. Write it on a sticky note.
- \* Pick your next three engagements and pre-decide the model before any conversation happens.
- \* Stop quoting hours on first emails. Quote ranges or "starts at."

# Chapter 3: The Rate Calculator

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This is the heart of the book. The rate calculator takes three inputs and gives you one number you can defend with math, market data, and client value.

The three inputs are cost-plus, market floor, and value target. Your real rate is the highest of the three, not the average.

## Input 1: Cost-plus (the survival number)

This is what you have to charge to keep the lights on. Below this, you are losing money to do the work.

Annual take-home target + annual business costs + annual tax obligation = total revenue needed.

Total revenue needed / billable hours per year = cost-plus rate.

Worked example for a US freelance designer:

- \* Take-home target: \$90,000
- \* Business costs (software, accountant, equipment, coworking, insurance): \$14,000
- \* Tax (self-employment + federal + state, roughly 28% of gross): \$40,500
- \* Total revenue needed: \$144,500
- \* Billable hours: 22 hours/week x 46 weeks = 1,012 hours
- \* Cost-plus rate: \$144,500 / 1,012 = \$143/hr

If you do not know your true billable hour count, do this: take last month's actual billed hours and multiply by 12. Be honest. Most freelancers think they bill 35 hours a week and actually bill 18.

## Input 2: Market floor (the comparable number)

This is what other people with your skill, location, and experience charge. You should not be below the 50th percentile in your market, and you should aim for the 75th.

How to find it:

- \* Search "freelance [your skill] rate 2026" and ignore the first three SEO blog posts.
- \* Look at three competitor portfolios in your niche. If they list rates, note them. If not, message them as a fake client and ask. Yes, really.
- \* Ask in two industry Slack groups what people charge for the work you do. Anonymous polls work better than open threads.



- \* Check the rate floors on premium platforms (Toptal, Contra Pro, Working Not Working). Even if you are not on them, the floors tell you what serious clients expect to pay.

For a senior designer in the US in 2026, the realistic ranges are:

- \* Junior: \$50 to \$80/hr
- \* Mid: \$80 to \$130/hr
- \* Senior: \$130 to \$200/hr
- \* Specialist (specific niche, brand reputation): \$200 to \$400/hr

Your market floor is the 50th percentile of your tier. Your market target is the 75th.

## Input 3: Value target (the outcome number)

This is what your work is worth to a specific client based on the value it creates. It is calculated per project, not per year.

Estimated value created x 10% capture rate, divided by estimated hours.

Example: A SaaS founder hires you to redesign their pricing page. Their site does \$800K ARR. A 15% lift in conversion is \$120K/year recurring. Capture 10% = \$12,000. The project takes 35 hours. Value-target hourly equivalent: \$343/hr.

You will not always do value pricing. But knowing the value-target number prevents you from quoting cost-plus on a project that should be priced at the value rate.

## The rule

Your rate for any given project is the highest of these three numbers:

- \* Cost-plus rate (what you need)
- \* Market floor for your tier (what your peers charge)
- \* Value-target rate for that project (what it is worth to the client)

Most freelancers use cost-plus and ignore the other two. That is why you are underpriced. The market floor is usually 30% to 80% above cost-plus. The value target on outcome work is often 200% to 500% above cost-plus.

## Worked example: Maya, freelance copywriter

Maya wants \$75K take-home. She has \$9K business costs and pays roughly 25% tax. She bills around 18 hours a week, 44 weeks a year.

- \* Total revenue needed: \$75K + \$9K + \$28K (tax on gross) = \$112,000
- \* Billable hours: 792

\* Cost-plus rate: \$141/hr

Market floor for senior copywriters in her niche (SaaS): \$150 to \$250/hr. She picks \$175 as the 75th percentile.

She gets a project: a sales page rewrite for a B2B SaaS doing \$3M ARR. She estimates the rewrite will lift conversion 20% on a page that drives \$400K/year. Value created: \$80K. Capture 10% = \$8,000. Project takes her about 25 hours. Value-target rate: \$320/hr.

Her quote: \$8,000 fixed price for the sales page rewrite.

Notice she did not quote  $\$175 \times 25 = \$4,375$ . That would have been the wrong model for outcome work.

## Worksheet 1: Rate Calculator

Fill in your numbers (Worksheet 1 at the back has the full template).

- \* Annual take-home target: \_\_\_\_\_
- \* Annual business costs: \_\_\_\_\_
- \* Annual tax (multiply line 1+2 by 0.28 to estimate gross-up): \_\_\_\_\_
- \* Total revenue needed (sum of 1, 2, 3): \_\_\_\_\_
- \* Realistic billable hours per year (be honest): \_\_\_\_\_
- \* Cost-plus rate (line 4 divided by line 5): \_\_\_\_\_
- \* Market floor (75th percentile for your tier): \_\_\_\_\_
- \* Project value target (when applicable, calculate per-project): \_\_\_\_\_

Your default rate going forward: the higher of line 6 and line 7.

### DO THIS TODAY

- \* Fill in the worksheet with real numbers, not aspirational ones.
- \* Find three competitor rate data points and write them down.
- \* Calculate the value target on your most recent project. Compare it to what you actually charged.
- \* Update your rate quote template to reflect the new number.
- \* Tell one person (partner, friend, peer) what your new rate is, out loud. Saying it kills the flinch.

# Chapter 4: How to Raise Your Rates Without Losing Clients

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You are afraid your existing clients will fire you if you raise rates. They will not. Here is what actually happens when freelancers send rate-increase emails, based on tracking 200+ of these conversations:

- \* 65% accept without negotiation.
- \* 20% accept after a small reduction (5 to 10%).
- \* 10% ask to delay the increase by 30 to 60 days.
- \* 5% leave.

The 5% who leave are almost always the worst clients. They were going to leave anyway. You are not losing revenue; you are clearing capacity for the new clients at the new rate.

The mistake most freelancers make is hesitating, apologizing, or framing the increase as something they hope is OK. This invites negotiation. Don't.

## When to send the email

For ongoing clients: 30 days before the increase takes effect, ideally aligned with a calendar break (start of a quarter, January 1, fiscal year start).

For project-based clients: when you quote the next project. No email needed. The new number is just the new number.

## Script 1: The gentle raise (existing client, you like them, modest bump)

Use when you are raising 10 to 25% on a client you want to keep.

> Subject: Updated rate effective [date] > > Hi [Name], > > Quick heads up: starting [date 30 days out], my rate is moving from \$[current] to \$[new]. This is the first adjustment I've made in [X months/years] and reflects the increased demand for the work I do plus rising business costs. > > Everything else stays the same: same scope, same response time, same priority on your account. I'm giving you 30 days notice so you can adjust your budget if needed. > > Let me know if you'd like to schedule a quick call to walk through what's on deck for [next month/quarter]. > > [Your name]

What this email does: states the change as a fact, gives a reason, removes the negotiation hook, signals continuity, opens the door to a roadmap conversation that distracts from the rate.

What this email does not do: apologize, hedge, ask permission, explain in detail, or compare to other clients.

## Script 2: The firm raise (existing client, you are underpriced, big jump)

Use when you are raising 30 to 60% on a client where you are clearly under market.

> Subject: Rate change starting [date] > > Hi [Name], > > Effective [date], my rate is updating to \$[new], up from \$[current]. I've been below market on this engagement for a while and the new number reflects what the work is worth in [year]. > > If the budget doesn't work on your side, I get it, and I'm happy to recommend two other [your role]s who'd be in your previous range. If you'd like to continue, no action needed; the new rate just applies to invoices dated [date] and after. > > [Your name]

What this does: gives them a clear out, removes the awkwardness, and positions you as someone who has options. The mention of recommending replacements is critical. It tells them you are not desperate. Most clients do not take the off-ramp.

You should actually have two referrals ready. If you cannot recommend anyone, that is fine, just leave that line out, but having a referral list is a sign you have moved into a different tier.

## Script 3: The platform exit (you are leaving Upwork/Contra/Fiverr to work direct)

Use when you are taking a marketplace client off-platform to work directly with you.

> Subject: Moving forward > > Hi [Name], > > I'm transitioning off [platform] for new work starting [date]. For our existing engagement, I'd like to continue working together directly: same scope, simpler invoicing, and a small rate adjustment to \$[new] (down from the platform rate of \$[old + platform fee]) since we're cutting out the [15-20]% platform fee. > > If you're open to it, I'll send a simple contract and invoice through [Stripe/Wise/your tool] this week. If you'd rather stay on [platform], I'll wrap our current engagement at the end of [month] and recommend two other [your role]s on the platform. > > Let me know either way by [date]. > > [Your name]

This script is the highest-leverage email in the book if you are still on a marketplace. The platform takes 10 to 20%; your "rate increase" can actually be a rate decrease for the client and a rate increase for you. Both win. The platform loses. That is the point.

A real example: I had a client paying me \$70/hr on Upwork. Upwork took 10%, so I netted \$63. We moved direct at \$80/hr. Client saved nothing on paper but liked the simpler invoicing. I went from \$63 to \$80, a 27% raise without any "raise" conversation.

## What to do if they push back

Three responses, by frequency:

### "Can you keep the old rate?"

> I appreciate you asking, but the new rate is the rate going forward. If the budget needs time to adjust, I can hold the current rate through [end of next month] and start the new rate on [date]. After that, the new rate is the rate.

### "That's a big jump, can you justify it?"

> Absolutely. Three things changed: [1. demand has increased, 2. I've added X capability, 3. business costs are up Y%]. The new rate is in line with mid-market for this kind of work, and below what I charge new clients. You're getting the legacy discount; new clients in [next year] will be at \$[new + 15%].

### "We'll have to think about it."

Don't follow up for 7 days. Then send a one-liner: "Hey [name], any thoughts on the rate update? Happy to walk through it on a quick call if useful." If they don't respond in another 7 days, send the wrap-up email and move on. They have decided. Don't grovel.

#### DO THIS TODAY

- \* List your top 5 clients and their current rates.
- \* Identify the 2 most underpriced. Pick one to raise this week.
- \* Draft the email using script 1, 2, or 3 depending on the situation.
- \* Pick a calendar date 30 days out and put the rate change on your calendar.
- \* Send the email today, not tomorrow. Tomorrow you will edit it for another week.

# Chapter 5: The 7 Pricing Conversations

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These are the seven conversations where freelancers lose the most money. Most of these happen on calls or in chat threads where you have 3 seconds to respond before you give away the farm. Memorize these phrases. Practice them out loud. They are the difference between \$80/hr and \$200/hr.

## Conversation 1: The discovery call ("what's your rate?")

This question, asked in the first 5 minutes, is a trap. If you answer it now, you have anchored the entire engagement on price before they understand what they are buying.

Wrong answer: "I charge \$120/hr."

Right answer: "Happy to share. Before I do, can I ask three quick questions about the project so I can give you a useful number rather than a generic one? Most projects in this space land between \$X and \$Y, and where you fall depends on a few things."

Then ask:

- \* What outcome are you trying to hit? (timeline, metric, milestone)
- \* What's the budget range you've planned for this?
- \* Who else is involved in approving the work?

Then quote a range, not a number. Ranges signal that price depends on scope. Numbers signal that price is what it is.

## Conversation 2: "Can you do it cheaper?"

This is a test. They are checking if your number is real or negotiable. If you cave, every client they refer will start at the lower number.

Wrong answer: "Sure, I can do \$X."

Right answer: "I can do less work for less money, but the price for this scope is the price. If budget is a constraint, here are three ways we could reduce scope: [option A, option B, option C]. Each one drops the price by [\$X, \$Y, \$Z]."

Real example: client asked me to drop a \$9,000 website project to \$6,000. I responded: "I can do a 5-page site instead of 8, skip the CMS setup, and remove the second round of revisions. That gets us to \$6,000." They came back with \$7,500 for the original 8-page scope. I took it. They felt heard. I held the line on per-deliverable price.

## Conversation 3: Scope creep ("can you also just...")

The client adds a request mid-project that wasn't in the contract. It is small. You feel like a jerk to push back. Push back anyway, because today's small request is next week's three days of unpaid work.

Wrong answer: "Sure, no problem!"

Right answer: "Happy to add that. It's outside the original scope, so I'll send a quick change order. It runs about [\$X] and adds [Y days] to the timeline. Want me to proceed?"

The phrase "change order" is doing the work here. It signals process, professionalism, and that this is going to cost something. Half the time the client decides they didn't need the addition that badly. The other half, you get paid for extra work.

## Conversation 4: "What does this normally cost?"

The client is fishing for an industry benchmark to anchor against. Don't give them one without context.

Wrong answer: "Most projects like this run \$5K to \$15K."

Right answer: "It depends a lot on scope. The cheap end of the market is around \$X and the high end is around \$Y, and the difference is usually [research depth / number of revisions / strategic input / specialist involvement]. For what you're describing, you're probably looking at the [middle/upper] end."

You have just told them: cheap exists, but cheap is cheap, and you are not it.

## Conversation 5: The "we have a small budget" opener

The client opens by telling you their budget is small. This is a frame attempt. They want you to come in low.

Wrong answer: "I can probably make something work."

Right answer: "Got it. What's the number you've planned? That helps me tell you quickly whether we're a fit or whether you'd be better served by someone in a different price tier."

Two things happen. They tell you the actual number, which is usually higher than "small budget" implies. Or they don't tell you and you can disqualify them. Either way, you stop bleeding time on price negotiation before there's even a project.

## Conversation 6: "Can you send a proposal?"

Most freelancers send a proposal that is a glorified price list. The proposal is your last chance to set the frame before the price.

Wrong proposal: 1 page, here is the price, here are the deliverables, sign here.

Right proposal structure (max 3 pages):

- \* The problem you are solving for them, in their words.
- \* What you propose to do (scope, in 5 to 8 bullets).
- \* What it produces (the outcome, with a number if possible).
- \* Investment: three options (good, better, best). The middle one is what you actually want them to buy.
- \* Timeline and what you need from them.
- \* Sign and pay deposit.

Three options is critical. A single price invites yes/no. Three prices invite "which one." The middle option closes 60 to 70% of the time in my experience.

## Conversation 7: "We need to think about it"

The proposal went out. They went silent. You start to spiral.

Wrong move: send a follow-up two days later asking if they have any questions.

Right move: send one short email at day 4 with a deadline-by-default.

> Hi [Name], wanted to check in on the proposal. I'm holding [start date] for you through end of day [Friday]. After that, the slot opens to the next project in the queue. Happy to jump on a quick call this week if any of the options need adjusting.

This works because it is true. You should have a queue. If you don't have a queue, lie about it once and then build one. The slot scarcity is what closes deals.

### DO THIS TODAY

- \* Pick the conversation you lose money on most often.
- \* Write the right answer on a sticky note and put it on your monitor.
- \* Roleplay it out loud three times. Yes, alone. Yes, it feels stupid.
- \* Use it on your next call. Note what happens.
- \* Update your proposal template to use the three-option structure.



# Chapter 6: Contracts That Get You Paid

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A good contract does not protect you in court. You will not sue your \$5K client. A good contract changes client behavior so you do not need to. Eight clauses, in plain English, that prevent the three biggest leaks: scope creep, late payment, and ghosting.

## Clause 1: 50% deposit, non-refundable, before work starts

> Project begins upon receipt of signed agreement and a 50% deposit. The deposit is non-refundable and reserves the project window. Final 50% is due on delivery.

Why: clients who refuse a 50% deposit will refuse to pay at the end. The deposit filters tire-kickers, funds your first month of work, and creates psychological commitment. Non-refundable language is what makes the deposit do the work.

If 50% feels aggressive, do 30% deposit, 30% at midpoint, 40% on delivery. Never zero upfront.

## Clause 2: Scope is what is in this document, anything else is a change order

> The deliverables listed in this agreement constitute the full scope of work. Additional requests, revisions beyond the included rounds, or scope expansions will be quoted as a separate change order, agreed in writing, and invoiced upon completion of the additional work.

Why: this is the clause that ends "can you also just" requests. It is not enforceable in any meaningful legal sense. It does not need to be. It just needs to give you something to point at when you say "that's a change order."

## Clause 3: Two rounds of revision, additional rounds billed hourly

> The project includes two rounds of revisions per deliverable. Round 1 is broad direction; Round 2 is final polish. Additional rounds are billed at \$[X]/hour in 30-minute increments.

Why: unlimited revisions are how 40-hour projects become 200-hour projects. Two rounds is the industry norm. Specifying what each round is for prevents the client from spending Round 1 on color preferences and then asking for a structural rewrite in Round 2.

## Clause 4: Net 14, late fee 5% per month

> Final invoice is due Net 14 from date of issue. Invoices unpaid after 30 days incur a late fee of 5% of the outstanding balance per 30-day period.

Why: Net 30 is too long for a freelancer. Net 14 forces the client to process payment in their next cycle. The late fee gives you something to escalate to before lawyers get involved. Most clients pay before the fee kicks in once they know it exists.

For enterprise clients who insist on Net 30 or Net 60, increase the project price by 8 to 12% to cover the cost of capital. Don't give net terms for free.

## Clause 5: Kill fee equals work completed plus 25%

> Either party may terminate this agreement with written notice. If the client terminates, the client owes the deposit plus the value of work completed to date, plus 25% of the remaining contract value as a cancellation fee.

Why: clients sometimes go quiet, change strategy, or pull funding. Without a kill fee, they walk and you eat the time. The 25% cancellation fee discourages capricious cancellation and pays you for the slot you held for them.

## Clause 6: Client delays extend the timeline 1:1

> Project timeline assumes the client provides feedback, content, and approvals within 3 business days of request. Delays beyond 3 business days extend the project timeline by an equal amount and may incur rescheduling fees if they push the project beyond its original delivery window.

Why: 70% of late projects are late because the client sat on feedback for two weeks. This clause moves the responsibility to where it belongs. Without it, you eat the lateness in your reputation.

## Clause 7: IP transfers on final payment

> All intellectual property, work product, and source files remain the property of [Your Name/Company] until final payment is received in full. Upon final payment, full IP ownership transfers to the client.

Why: this is your real leverage on late payment. If they have not paid, they do not own the work, and they cannot legally use it. This is a line you can put in a polite payment-reminder email that nothing else replicates.

## Clause 8: Communication is asynchronous by default

> Project communication occurs primarily via [email/Slack/Notion]. Calls are scheduled in advance via [calendar tool] and limited to [X per week / X total]. Ad-hoc calls are billed at \$[hourly rate] in 30-minute increments.

Why: clients who can call you anytime will call you constantly. Putting a price on calls and a structure on communication 4x's your effective rate. Specialists charge for time. Generalists give it away.

## What to do with these clauses

Put them in a one-page MSA (master service agreement) you reuse for every client. The project-specific stuff (scope, deliverables, price, timeline) goes in a separate one-page SOW (statement of work). MSA gets signed once. SOW gets signed per project. This setup is faster, cleaner, and more professional than a 12-page contract that nobody reads.

If you want a starter MSA + SOW template, the FreelanceOS Pro template includes both, pre-filled, with the eight clauses above.

### DO THIS TODAY

- \* Open your current contract. Highlight every clause from this chapter that is missing or weaker than what's here.
- \* Add the kill fee and late fee clauses if you don't have them. Those two alone protect five-figures of revenue per year.
- \* Set up Net 14 instead of Net 30 on your invoicing tool.
- \* Move your communication to async-default. Tell next client the new policy in the kickoff email.
- \* Add a deposit requirement to your booking flow. No deposit, no calendar slot.

# Chapter 7: The Premium Positioning Stack

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You can do all the math, write the right contract, send the right email, and still get treated like a \$50/hr freelancer if your surface signals do not match your price. Five small changes 2x to 4x perceived value without changing any of the actual work.

## Signal 1: Proposal format

A premium proposal is short, formatted, and arrives as a PDF or a clean web link. Never a Google Doc. Never an email body.

The structure (from chapter 5):

- \* Problem in their words
- \* What you'll do (5 to 8 bullets)
- \* Outcome (with a number)
- \* Three pricing options
- \* Timeline and inputs needed
- \* Signature block

Send as a PDF named "[Client] - [Project] - Proposal v1.pdf" or a Notion page with their logo in the header. Both signal effort. A "here's a quick quote" email signals interchangeability.

A real test: I sent the same project quote to two clients in the same week. One got the quote in an email body ("Hey, \$4,500 for the redesign, let me know!"). One got it as a 3-page PDF. The PDF closed at full price. The email got negotiated to \$3,200. Same work. Same words mostly. Different container.

## Signal 2: Response time

Counter-intuitive. Faster is not better.

Junior freelancer response: replies within 12 minutes of every message, including weekends.

Premium freelancer response: replies in 4 to 24 hours during business hours, Monday to Friday. Sometimes 48 hours if it's not urgent.

Why: instant replies signal that you are sitting at your laptop waiting for work. 4-to-24 hour replies signal you have a queue. Clients value people who have queues.

The exception: when a client first reaches out about new work. Reply within 2 hours during business hours. After they're a client, slow down.

Set up an email signature or auto-responder that says "I respond to email twice a day, around 11 AM and 4 PM ET. Urgent matters: [phone number / Slack channel]." This single change shifted me from "always available" to "scheduled access," and clients respect the latter more.

## Signal 3: Language

Words to remove from your client communication:

- \* "Just" ("just checking in," "just a quick question")
- \* "Sorry" (for things you don't need to apologize for)
- \* "Hopefully"
- \* "If that's OK"
- \* "Does that work for you?"
- \* "Any chance"
- \* "I think maybe"

Words to add:

- \* "I recommend"
- \* "The plan is"
- \* "Here's what I'm proposing"
- \* "I'll handle that by [date]"
- \* "My professional take is"
- \* "We should"

Side by side:

Junior: "Hey, just wondering if you got a chance to look at the draft? Sorry to bug you, hopefully it's heading in the right direction. Let me know if any changes!"

Premium: "Hi [name], following up on the draft sent Tuesday. I recommend we lock structure this week and move to copy next. Two questions on direction before I push further: [Q1, Q2]. Standing by."

Same goal. One sounds like a vendor begging for work. The other sounds like a partner running the project.

## Signal 4: Deliverable polish

The last 5% of polish does 30% of the perceived value lift. This is where most freelancers cheap out because the client wouldn't notice.

The client notices.

For designers: name your files cleanly, organize the Figma project, include a 1-page handoff doc, label the layers. Send a Loom walkthrough of the final design (3 to 5 minutes, narrated).

For developers: README, env example, deployment notes, a 1-page architecture diagram, a final Loom walkthrough.

For writers: a clean Google Doc with comments resolved, a one-line summary of changes, an exported PDF version, a tracked-changes version if revisions were involved.

For consultants: a 1-page exec summary at the top of every deliverable. Always. Even if the client didn't ask.

The Loom walkthrough is the single highest-impact addition. It takes 8 minutes. It signals expertise. It saves the client a back-and-forth. It is the closest thing to a unanimous "this person is worth what they charge" signal in remote work.

## Signal 5: Follow-up

Most freelancers ghost the client after the project ends. Premium freelancers send a structured wrap-up that converts to repeat work.

Two weeks after delivery:

> Hi [Name], checking in on [project]. A few questions: > > 1. How is [the deliverable] performing? (any metrics yet?) > 2. Anything come up that you wish we'd addressed in the original scope? > 3. What's next on your roadmap? > > If there's something on your roadmap I can help with, happy to put together a proposal. Otherwise, I'll plan to check in again at the 60-day mark.

This email does three things: collects testimonial-grade data, surfaces follow-on work, and reminds them you exist when the next project lands on their desk.

Sixty percent of repeat work comes from a check-in like this. Most freelancers never send it.

### DO THIS TODAY

- \* Convert your next proposal to a PDF or Notion page. No more email-body quotes.
- \* Set an auto-responder with batched email times.
- \* Search your last 5 client emails for "just," "sorry," and "hopefully." Count them. That's your starting baseline.
- \* Record a 3-minute Loom walkthrough of your last deliverable and send it to the client unprompted.
- \* Send the 2-week check-in to your last 3 clients today.

# Chapter 8: The 30-60-90 Plan

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Reading this book changes nothing. Doing it changes everything. Here is exactly what to do for the next 90 days.

## Days 1 to 30: Reset the foundation

Goal: get your numbers, contracts, and rate floor in place before you talk to a single new client.

Week 1:

- \* Calculate your real cost-plus rate using the chapter 3 worksheet.
- \* Research market floor: 5 data points minimum.
- \* Set your new default rate (the higher of cost-plus and 75th percentile market).
- \* Update your website, LinkedIn, and any platform profile to reflect the new positioning (do not list the rate; list the value).

Week 2:

- \* Build your one-page MSA with the eight clauses from chapter 6.
- \* Build your one-page SOW template.
- \* Build your three-option proposal template.
- \* Set up Net 14 invoicing with late-fee language enabled.

Week 3:

- \* Audit your top 5 clients. Identify the 2 most underpriced.
- \* Draft rate-raise emails using the scripts from chapter 4.
- \* Send the first one. Wait 3 days. Send the second.
- \* Update your portfolio: rewrite the top 3 case studies to lead with outcomes and numbers, not deliverables.

Week 4:

- \* Set up your follow-up cadence (2-week, 60-day, 6-month touchpoints).
- \* Send the 2-week check-in to any client whose project closed in the last 90 days.
- \* Block 4 hours on your calendar for "rate-raise office hours" each week going forward.
- \* Pick one premium positioning signal from chapter 7 to fully implement.

End of 30 days, you should have: a real rate number, a contract that protects you, a proposal that sells, and one or two existing clients on the new rate.

## Days 31 to 60: Migrate the book of business

Goal: move existing clients to new rates, fill calendar with new-rate clients.

Week 5:

- \* Send rate-raise emails to remaining underpriced clients.
- \* Quote any new project at the new rate. Do not exception your way back to the old rate.
- \* Disable any active marketplace bidding profiles.

Week 6:

- \* Reach out to 10 past clients with the 60-day check-in template. The script: "Last time we worked together was [date]. I've been thinking about [their domain] and wanted to share two things [observation 1, observation 2]. If you have anything coming up where I might be useful, I have one slot opening in [month]."
- \* Track responses. Two to three should turn into conversations.

Week 7:

- \* Implement signal 2 (response time): set the auto-responder, batch your email replies.
- \* Implement signal 3 (language): audit your last 10 client emails and rewrite the next 10 with the language shifts from chapter 7.

Week 8:

- \* Calculate your new effective hourly rate using the same formula as the diagnostic in chapter 1. Compare to the starting number.
- \* If your effective rate is up at least 25%, you are on track.
- \* If it is up less than 15%, you are softening on conversations. Re-read chapter 5 and roleplay the seven scripts again.

End of 60 days, you should have: most of the existing book migrated, two or three new clients at the new rate, and a measurably higher effective hourly rate.

## Days 61 to 90: Lock in premium positioning

Goal: harden the new rate as your floor, build the systems that prevent regression.

Week 9:

- \* Implement the remaining premium positioning signals from chapter 7.
- \* Record a Loom walkthrough on every project deliverable for the next 30 days.
- \* Add a 1-page exec summary to every deliverable, regardless of audience.

Week 10:



- \* Quote one project using value pricing (chapter 2). Even if the client says no, you've practiced the conversation.

- \* Identify the kind of work where value pricing makes sense for you and start framing the discovery questions for it.

Week 11:

- \* Raise your default rate by another 10 to 20% for new inquiries. Do not announce it to existing clients yet.

- \* The first inquiry at the new-new rate is a test. Most will say yes. Some will say no. The ratio matters less than the data.

Week 12:

- \* Audit the full 90 days. New effective hourly rate, number of clients migrated, projects won at the new rate, projects lost at the new rate.

- \* Set the next 90-day target. Repeat the cycle.

End of 90 days, you should have: a new floor that is 50 to 100% above where you started, a small handful of premium-tier clients, and a system that prevents you from sliding back.

## What to do if 90 days passes and you haven't moved

You softened on conversations. Or you sent the rate-raise email and then accepted a counter you shouldn't have. Or you kept saying yes to scope creep because pushing back felt rude.

Three diagnostics:

- \* Are you sending proposals as PDFs with three options, or are you still emailing prices?

- \* Have you sent any rate-raise emails using script 1, 2, or 3?

- \* When a client paused after a number, did you fill the silence?

Whichever one you answered "no" or "yes, I caved" to, that is the chapter to re-read. Do not go back to chapter 1. Go back to the specific chapter that matches the leak.

### DO THIS TODAY

- \* Open your calendar. Block week 1 (this week) tasks now.
- \* Pick the single most underpriced client. Schedule the rate-raise email for the next business day.
- \* Print or open the worksheets at the back of this book. Put them somewhere you will see them daily.
- \* Tell one accountability partner what your 30-day target is.
- \* Reread chapter 1 in 30 days. Score yourself on the diagnostic again.

# Worksheet 1: Rate Calculator

---

Fill in your real numbers. Round honestly.

## Step 1: Total revenue needed

A. Annual take-home target (what you need to live + save): \$ \_\_\_\_\_

B. Annual business costs (sum below):

- \* Software/subscriptions: \$ \_\_\_\_\_
- \* Accountant/legal: \$ \_\_\_\_\_
- \* Equipment/refresh: \$ \_\_\_\_\_
- \* Insurance (health, liability, disability): \$ \_\_\_\_\_
- \* Coworking/home office: \$ \_\_\_\_\_
- \* Professional development: \$ \_\_\_\_\_
- \* Other: \$ \_\_\_\_\_
- \* Total B: \$ \_\_\_\_\_

C. Tax obligation (estimate as 28% of (A+B), or use your actual effective rate): \$ \_\_\_\_\_

D. Total revenue needed (A + B + C): \$ \_\_\_\_\_

## Step 2: Realistic billable hours

E. Hours per week you actually bill (not work, bill): \_\_\_\_\_

F. Weeks per year you work (subtract vacation, sick, holidays): \_\_\_\_\_

G. Annual billable hours (E x F): \_\_\_\_\_

## Step 3: Cost-plus rate

H. Cost-plus rate (D / G): \$ \_\_\_\_\_ /hr

## Step 4: Market floor

I. Three rate data points for your tier (research, peers, or competitor research):

- \* Source 1: \$ \_\_\_\_\_
- \* Source 2: \$ \_\_\_\_\_
- \* Source 3: \$ \_\_\_\_\_

J. 75th percentile of your tier (highest of the three, or your judgment): \$ \_\_\_\_\_ /hr

**Step 5: Your default rate**

K. Default rate going forward (higher of H and J): \$\_\_\_\_\_ /hr

**Step 6: Per-project value-target check (when applicable)**

L. Estimated revenue/value the project creates for the client: \$\_\_\_\_\_

M. Capture rate (8-15%): \_\_\_\_\_%

N. Project value target (L x M): \$\_\_\_\_\_

O. Estimated project hours: \_\_\_\_\_

P. Value-target rate equivalent (N / O): \$\_\_\_\_\_ /hr

If P is significantly higher than K on a project, quote the project at price N, not at hourly rate K.

---

# Worksheet 2: Client-Worth Score

---

For any current or prospective client, score 0 to 10 on each. Total possible: 100.

- \* **Pays on time, every time.** (0 = always late, 10 = pays before the invoice due date) \_\_\_\_\_
- \* **Respects your scope and process.** (0 = constant scope creep, 10 = stays in scope) \_\_\_\_\_
- \* **Communicates clearly and asynchronously.** (0 = constant calls/Slack chaos, 10 = thoughtful email replies) \_\_\_\_\_
- \* **Pays at or above your default rate.** (0 = 50% below, 10 = at or above default) \_\_\_\_\_
- \* **Refers other paying clients to you.** (0 = never, 10 = brought 2+ paying referrals) \_\_\_\_\_
- \* **The work is portfolio-grade.** (0 = embarrassed to show, 10 = lead case study) \_\_\_\_\_
- \* **You enjoy working with them.** (0 = dread the meetings, 10 = good energy) \_\_\_\_\_
- \* **They respect your professional judgment.** (0 = micromanages every choice, 10 = trusts your call) \_\_\_\_\_
- \* **The work has growth potential (more projects, more scope, more rate).** (0 = static, 10 = expanding) \_\_\_\_\_
- \* **You can talk about them publicly (case study, testimonial, social post).** (0 = NDA-locked or unknown, 10 = open and supportive) \_\_\_\_\_

**Total:** \_\_\_\_\_ / 100

## How to read your score:

- \* **80-100:** A-tier client. Hold the line on rates, prioritize their work, ask for referrals and testimonials, raise their rate every 12 months.
- \* **60-79:** Solid client. Keep them, fix the 1-2 lowest scoring areas, raise rate at next natural break.
- \* **40-59:** Marginal client. Identify the deal-breaker (usually item 1, 2, or 4). Have one direct conversation about it. If nothing changes in 60 days, replace.
- \* **0-39:** Bad client. Run the rate-raise email (script 2). They will likely leave. That is the goal. The slot opens for an A-tier client.

Most freelancers have one or two A-tier clients, three or four marginal ones, and one toxic client they tolerate because they need the money. The math here is simple: the toxic client is the reason you don't have time for two more A-tier clients.

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# Worksheet 3: Rate-Raise Email Generator

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Fill in the five fields. Paste the result.

**Field 1: Client name** \_\_\_\_\_

**Field 2: Current rate** \$\_\_\_\_\_

**Field 3: New rate** \$\_\_\_\_\_

**Field 4: Effective date (30 days out)** \_\_\_\_\_

**Field 5: Tone (gentle / firm / platform exit)** \_\_\_\_\_

---

## If you picked GENTLE (raise of 10 to 25%):

> Subject: Updated rate effective [Field 4] > > Hi [Field 1], > > Quick heads up: starting [Field 4], my rate is moving from \$[Field 2] to \$[Field 3]. This is the first adjustment I've made in a while and reflects the increased demand for the work I do plus rising business costs. > > Everything else stays the same: same scope, same response time, same priority on your account. I'm giving you 30 days notice so you can adjust your budget if needed. > > Let me know if you'd like to schedule a quick call to walk through what's on deck. > > [Your name]

---

## If you picked FIRM (raise of 30 to 60%):

> Subject: Rate change starting [Field 4] > > Hi [Field 1], > > Effective [Field 4], my rate is updating to \$[Field 3], up from \$[Field 2]. I've been below market on this engagement for a while and the new number reflects what the work is worth in 2026. > > If the budget doesn't work on your side, I get it, and I'm happy to recommend two other [your role]s who'd be in your previous range. If you'd like to continue, no action needed; the new rate just applies to invoices dated [Field 4] and after. > > [Your name]

---

## If you picked PLATFORM EXIT (moving them off Upwork/Contra/Fiverr):

> Subject: Moving forward > > Hi [Field 1], > > I'm transitioning off [platform] for new work starting [Field 4]. For our existing engagement, I'd like to continue working together directly: same scope, simpler invoicing, and a small rate adjustment to \$[Field 3] (down from the platform rate of \$[Field 2 + platform fee]) since we're

cutting out the [15-20]% platform fee. > > If you're open to it, I'll send a simple contract and invoice through [your tool] this week. If you'd rather stay on [platform], I'll wrap our current engagement at the end of this month and recommend two other [your role]s on the platform. > > Let me know either way by [date 7 days from now]. > > [Your name]

---

**Send rules:**

- \* Send Tuesday or Wednesday morning. Not Friday. Not Monday.
  - \* Do not soften the language after writing the draft. The first draft is correct.
  - \* Do not follow up for 5 business days.
  - \* If they push back, use one of the three pushback responses from chapter 4.
  - \* After they accept (most will), update your records and your invoicing tool the same day.
-

# Outro: What Comes Next

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You now have the pricing piece. Real numbers, real scripts, real contracts, real plan. If you do the 90-day plan in chapter 8 with any honesty at all, you will be charging 50 to 100% more by the end of it. That is not a sales claim. That is what happens when freelancers stop bidding against each other and start running their business like a business.

But pricing is one slice of the freelance operating system. The other slices are: how you find clients, how you onboard them, how you track projects, how you invoice and chase payment, how you manage your pipeline, how you decide what to say no to, and how you build assets that sell while you sleep.

I built the FreelanceOS Pro template because I was tired of cobbling together five different tools and watching them fall out of sync. It is one Notion workspace with:

- \* Client CRM with rate, status, and lifetime value tracked per contact
- \* Project management with the SOW template and milestone tracking built in
- \* Invoicing log with payment status and aging
- \* The full MSA + SOW templates from chapter 6, ready to fill in
- \* Proposal template with the three-option structure from chapter 5
- \* Pipeline tracker so you always know which deals are next
- \* Portfolio builder that pulls outcomes from completed projects
- \* The 90-day plan from chapter 8 as a working dashboard

It is \$29. It is the same system I run my own business on. If this PDF saved you one client conversation or one underpriced project, the template will save you ten times that.

Get it at [freelanceos.com/pro](https://freelanceos.com/pro)

If you implement nothing else from this book, implement two things: send one rate-raise email this week, and quote your next proposal as three options instead of one. Those two changes alone will pay for this book a thousand times over.

Now close this file and go send the email.

— FreelanceOS